

Language Study in Spain

The Complete Map

Every route a Spanish course can take to a student authorisation — which centres fit which route, what each one is worth, and the four emails that settle the only question still open.

GOVERNING TEXT	RD 1155/2024, consolidated to 16 April 2026
KEY INSTRUMENTS	Instrucción SEM 3/2025 (20 June 2025) · Criterios de Gestión (23 June 2025)
APPLICANT PROFILE	Tunisian national · zero Spanish · Tunisian computing degree · budget ~€8,000
TARGET	Spanish course from January 2027, then a master's without leaving Spain
RECOMMENDATION	IELE, Universidad de Extremadura, Cáceres — 11 January 2027

The test, corrected

Three earlier versions of this test were wrong. This is the one the published texts actually support.

A Spanish course supports a long-stay student authorisation by **one of two routes**, and the route decides everything that follows — work rights, extensions, and whether you can convert to a work permit after your master's.

Route 1 — Article 52.1.a), *estudios superiores*

The strong route. Three conditions, all from Instrucción SEM 3/2025:

- The course is taught **face-to-face** (*presencial*) — not online, not hybrid
- It is delivered by a **recognised higher-education institution**
- The language is **not** your mother tongue, and **not** an official language of your country of nationality

"Conforme al artículo 52.1.a) del RLOEX, se considerarán como estudios superiores los estudios idiomáticos impartidos de forma presencial por las instituciones y centros de educación superior reconocidos."

"Under Article 52.1.a) of the RLOEX, language studies taught face-to-face by recognised higher-education institutions shall be considered higher studies."

INSTRUCCIÓN SEM 3/2025, PRIMERA.1 · PILAR CANCELA RODRÍGUEZ · 20 JUNE 2025

YOU PASS THE THIRD CONDITION

Tunisia's official language is Arabic. Spanish is neither your mother tongue nor an official language of your country. This clause silently shuts almost every Latin American applicant out of Route 1 — it does not touch you.

Route 2 — Article 52.1.e).2º, *estudios idiomáticos*

The weak route. No conditions about the course — only about the **venue**. It must be an **Escuela Oficial de Idiomas** or a centre **accredited by the Instituto Cervantes**. The list is closed:

"...no es admisible que sean cursados en establecimientos diferentes de estos."

"...it is not admissible that they be taken at establishments other than these."

CRITERIOS DE GESTIÓN §13

What the two routes are worth

SIDE BY SIDE

	ROUTE 1 — 52.1.A)	ROUTE 2 — 52.1.E).2º
Work	30 h/week, automatic , no extra application ART. 57.1¶4	Separate application required ART. 57.1¶1
Duration granted	Full official length of the course	Capped at 1 year ART. 55.1
Extensions	Two <i>prórrogas</i>	One , and only on passing DELE/SIELE/EOI
Family	May bring family ART. 56	No family rights
Convert to work permit	Yes — Art. 190	Excluded ART. 190.1
Master's application from Spain	Yes ART. 54.1§2	Yes — same article, if legally resident

THE ONE THAT REALLY HURTS

Article 190 is the whole point of your plan. It is how a student authorisation becomes a work permit after the master's, with no labour-market test and full-time work from the moment the file is admitted. Route 2 is expressly excluded from it. If your language year lands on 52.1.e).2º, the language year itself still works — but you must be on Route 1 by the time the master's ends.

Two filters that do NOT exist

I applied both of these earlier and both were wrong. They are worth stating so you never let a school or an agent tell you otherwise.

"En los estudios de idiomas, habrá de estarse a lo que determine el plan de estudios. La carga horaria semanal puede ser de pocas horas."

"In language studies, whatever the study plan determines applies. The weekly hours may be few."

CRITERIOS DE GESTIÓN §4 – THERE IS NO 20-HOUR MINIMUM FOR LANGUAGE COURSES

"En el caso de las enseñanzas superiores, existen los títulos oficiales y los títulos propios. Ambos son admisibles para la obtención de una autorización de estancia por estudios."

"In higher education there are official qualifications and universities' own qualifications. Both are admissible for obtaining a student authorisation."

CRITERIOS DE GESTIÓN §8 – AN OFFICIAL DEGREE IS NOT REQUIRED

THE REAL MINIMUM

The course must run at least **91 calendar days** (Criterios §3). A TIE is required only where the authorisation exceeds **six months** — the statute says *"superior a seis meses"*, which is 181–184 days depending on the dates, not a flat 180.

The five groups

Every Spanish course in Spain falls into one of these. Four of the five lead somewhere. One leads nowhere.

READ THIS BEFORE THE TABLES

These are the centres I **verified** against the Instituto Cervantes register of 192 accredited centres and against each university's own pages. **This is not a closed list of everything that qualifies.** Spain has 50 public and 39 private universities and nearly all run a language service; most would land in Group B. Absence from these tables means unverified, not disqualified.

GROUP A University's own centre *and* Instituto Cervantes-accredited

Both routes apply on their face. Strongest position — and the one place where the law is genuinely unresolved (Chapter 3).

CENTRE	CITY	PRICE / YEAR	JAN 2027 INTAKE
IELE — Univ. de Extremadura	Cáceres	€2,500 (12.5 months)	11 Jan 2027 ✓
CELE — Univ. de Zaragoza	Zaragoza	€2,230	ask
CLM — Univ. de Granada	Granada	~€3,000+	✓ quarterly
CIE — Univ. de Málaga	Málaga	€800 / 80h month	✓ monthly
UCOIdiomas — Univ. de Córdoba	Córdoba	ask	ask
ESTO — UCLM	Toledo	ask	ask
Centro de Idiomas UVA	Valladolid	ask	ask
Centre d'Idiomes UV	Valencia	ask	ask
Servicio de Idiomas UM	Murcia	ask	ask
Servei Lingüístic UIB	Palma de Mallorca	ask	ask
Idiomes UPF	Barcelona	ask	ask
UIMP	Santander	ask	ask
Univ. San Jorge PRIVATE	Zaragoza	ask	ask
Univ. Católica de Valencia PRIVATE	Valencia	ask	ask
UNEATLÁNTICO PRIVATE	Santander	ask	ask

GROUP B University's own department, *not* Cervantes-accredited

Route 1 only — which is the route you want anyway. No ambiguity here at all: the Instrucción covers them squarely.

CENTRE	CITY	PRICE / YEAR	NOTE
Cursos de Español — Complutense	Madrid	~€5,550	Expensive
Casa de las Lenguas — Univ. de Oviedo	Oviedo	ask	—
Estudios Hispánicos — Univ. de Barcelona	Barcelona	ask	High cost of living
ILCE — Univ. de Navarra PRIVATE	Pamplona	ask	Expensive
Univ. de León	León	ask	Cheap city
Univ. de Burgos	Burgos	ask	Cheap city
Univ. de La Rioja	Logroño	ask	Cheap city
Univ. Carlos III	Madrid	ask	—
Univ. Nebrija PRIVATE	Madrid	ask	—

GROUP C Taught by a university-owned company or foundation

Still Route 1 — this was my largest error, and it was backwards. Outsourced university teaching stays in *estudios superiores*, provided the paperwork exists.

"...el establecimiento que imparta las clases debe contar con un **convenio vigente de colaboración**; no es necesario que esté adscrito ni figure en el RUCT. A tal efecto, junto con la matrícula, se deberá aportar, como mínimo, una certificación expedida por la universidad..., un resumen del plan de estudios y del sistema de control y verificación sobre la institución colaboradora."

"...the establishment teaching the classes must have a collaboration agreement in force; it need not be attached to, nor appear in, the RUCT. To that effect, along with the enrolment, at minimum a certification issued by the university must be provided..., a summary of the study plan and of the control and verification system over the collaborating institution."

CRITERIOS DE GESTIÓN §9

CENTRE	UNIVERSITY	CITY	PRICE
Cursos Internacionales S.A.	Salamanca	Salamanca	~€5,100
Alcalingua S.R.L.	Alcalá	Alcalá de Henares	ask
Cursos de Español S.A.U. (CSIdiomas)	Alicante	Alicante	ask
Cursos Internacionales USC S.L.	Santiago	Santiago de Compostela	ask

ONE QUESTION DECIDES GROUP C

¿Existe un convenio vigente con la universidad, y el diploma lo expide la universidad? — If yes, Group C behaves exactly like Group B. If they cannot produce the *convenio*, walk away.

GROUP D Escuelas Oficiales de Idiomas

Public, and by far the cheapest in Spain — roughly €150–300 for a full year. Legally open under Route 2. My earlier claim that their low weekly hours disqualified them was **wrong**: Criterios §4 disposes of that objection entirely.

The real obstacles are calendar and length. EOIs enrol in **September only**, and the 91-day minimum has to be met. For a January 2027 start they are effectively closed — but if your plan ever slips to a September intake, an EOI is the cheapest legal course in the country.

GROUP E Private Instituto Cervantes-accredited schools

don Quijote, Enforex, AIL, Tandem and the rest. Legally valid — but Route 2 only, with every disadvantage in the Chapter 1 table. The Ministry is blunt about what they are:

*"Casos específicos son los centros acreditados en España por el Instituto Cervantes..., **que no se trata de centros educativos en sentido estricto.**"*

"Specific cases are centres accredited in Spain by the Instituto Cervantes..., which are not educational centres in the strict sense."

CRITERIOS DE GESTIÓN §9

NO GROUP What does not work at all

A private school that is **neither** Cervantes-accredited **nor** teaching a university course under a *convenio*. It is not a recognised higher-education institution, and it is not on the closed venue list. It fits nowhere. Many such schools advertise "student visa support" regardless. They cannot deliver it.

The question nobody has answered

One point remains genuinely open in the published texts. It is the point that decides your work rights, and no lawyer in Spain has written about it.

Cáceres IELE and Zaragoza CELE are **simultaneously** a university's own centre **and** Instituto Cervantes-accredited. Route 1 applies to them through the Instrucción. Route 2 applies to them through the venue list. **Both apply on their face, and no published text says which wins.**

What points towards Route 1

The Instrucción is unqualified. It says language studies taught face-to-face by recognised higher-education institutions *are* higher studies — with no carve-out for centres that happen also to hold Cervantes accreditation. Its stated purpose reinforces this:

*"La instrucción primera se refiere a los cursos de idiomas impartidos por las instituciones de educación superior, **con la finalidad de fomentar su internacionalización.**"*

"The first instruction refers to language courses taught by higher-education institutions, with the aim of promoting their internationalisation."

INSTRUCCIÓN SEM 3/2025, PREAMBLE

The instruction exists precisely to pull university language courses *into* Route 1. And it outranks the Criterios: it is signed by the **Secretaría de Estado de Migraciones**, while the Criterios come from a **Dirección General** one level below.

The words "Instituto Cervantes" and "escuelas oficiales de idiomas" **appear nowhere in the Instrucción**. It does not engage Route 2 at all.

What complicates it

Three days after the Instrucción, the Dirección General issued the Criterios, containing this sentence:

*"Dentro de los títulos propios de las universidades, se incluyen los idiomáticos de cualquier lengua, **siempre que conduzcan a la obtención de un título expedido por la universidad.**"*

"Among the universities' own qualifications are included language qualifications in any language, **provided they lead to a título issued by the university.**"

CRITERIOS DE GESTIÓN §9

Read broadly, that makes Route 1 conditional on the course ending in a **university-issued qualification** rather than a mere certificate of attendance.

MY READING — AND ITS LIMITS

§9 is headed "**EXTERNALIZACIÓN DE LA FORMACIÓN**" — outsourcing. The *título* condition is unambiguous for a course a university farms out to a company or foundation, because only *títulos propios* may be outsourced at all. For a course a university teaches **in-house**, §9 does not apply, and the Instrucción imposes no such condition.

But an officer could read that last sentence as a general definition of what a university language course must be. There is no published source telling you which way any given office will go. **So ask, on every option, in writing.**

Why you will not find the answer online

SOURCE CHECKED	RESULT
infoextranjería.org, Iberley, Sepín, vLex, Tirant, Aranzadi, La Ley	Announcement or restatement only. No overlap analysis.
ICAM Madrid bar — 50-slide deck on RD 1155/2024	Lists the two categories separately, never in contact. Predates the Instrucción.
Revista de Derecho Migratorio y Extranjería nº 68 (2025)	No article on <i>estudios idiomáticos</i> .
CENDOJ case law	None will exist. RD 1155/2024 took effect 20 May 2025; first-instance rulings run 18–36 months behind.
Every Spanish university	Not one mentions Instrucción SEM 3/2025 anywhere.

THE DECISIVE NEGATIVE SIGNAL

The phrase "*idiomáticos de cualquier lengua*" — the operative words above — returns **zero** results anywhere on the open web outside the source PDF. No firm, bar, publisher or blog quotes it. The profession has not read this passage.

Practical consequence: **hiring a general extranjería lawyer will most likely get you the two articles read back to you.** Put the §9 text in front of them at instruction, or you are paying someone to rediscover it.

ALSO: THERE IS NO BINDING ADVANCE RULING

Unlike tax law, which has *consultas vinculantes* under arts. 88–89 LGT, Spanish immigration law has **no statutory advance-ruling procedure**. Nothing you obtain in Chapter 6 binds the Administration. It is all informative.

What the universities actually say

Out of all 89 Spanish universities, exactly one publishes what article its language students get. That fact is worth more than any legal argument in this document.

Extremadura — the only one that commits

IELE states the full Route 1 package in four separate places. Each of these was verified against a saved copy of the page, not from memory.

"The visa entitles the holder to obtain a TIE (Foreigner Identity Card) and to work up to 30 hours per week during the period of study."

IELE Frequently Asked Questions, item 6 — iele.unex.es/frequently-asked-questions/

SOURCE 1 OF 4

SOURCE 2 – IELE MASTER'S PATHWAY PAGE. THE YEAR 1 COLUMN IS THE SPANISH COURSE BY ITSELF.

	YEAR 1 — SPANISH A1 → B2	YEAR 2 — MASTER'S
Weekly commitment	20 hours/week	10–16 hours/week
Work rights	Up to 30 hours/week	Up to 30 hours/week
Visa status	Study Visa / Student Residence Permit	Student Permit Extension

"Receive a 1-Year Spanish Study Permit (TIE) ... Residency permit can be extended from within Spain ... Legal authorization to work up to 30 hours/week during studies ... The TIE allows you to extend your stay after studies and transition to a permanent work permit."

Official IELE brochure, hosted on iele.unex.es, bearing the UEx crest and the Instituto Cervantes "Centro Acreditado" mark — section "STUDY, WORK & LIVE".

SOURCE 3 OF 4 – THIS IS THE PDF ALREADY IN YOUR POSSESSION

Source 4 is the Bachelor's Pathway page: *"Day 1 in Spain: Student Visa & 30h/week work permit."*

WHY THIS MATTERS SO MUCH

Automatic 30 hours + extension from inside Spain + conversion to a work permit. **That trio only exists under Route 1.** Under Route 2 you get none of the three. IELE is stating, on university letterhead, that its Spanish-course students are treated as *estudios superiores*.

TWO HONEST DISCOUNTS

IELE's own FAQ names a commercial recruiter, *Study in Spain Guide*, as the pathway partner, and these pages read as jointly produced with them. This may be marketing copy sitting on a university domain.

Their vocational page also says *"Student Residence 2 years permit at once"*, which is legally loose and suggests no lawyer reviewed the text.

Treat it as a strong statement of **how IELE expects its students to be classified** — not as proof of what any TIE actually said. That is precisely what the email in Chapter 5 is for.

The other three, and why they rank lower

CENTRE	WHAT THEY PUBLISH	VERDICT
Málaga CIE-UMA	Offers only " <i>una carta de invitación</i> " for the visa — an invitation letter , not a <i>carta de admisión a estudios superiores</i> . Nothing on work, hours or articles.	WEAK SIGNAL Drops in the ranking.
Granada CLM / UGR	UGR's student FAQ still says " <i>el propio empleador debe presentar una solicitud en la oficina de extranjería</i> " — the abolished pre-2025 rule . Their extranjería page also misdates RD 1155/2024 by a year.	RUNNING ON REPEALED LAW
Zaragoza CELE	Silent on work, hours, TIE and articles. One UNIZAR page still quotes the dead "20 hours per week" limit. Visa help is procedural only, conditional on the course exceeding three months.	SILENT Not disqualified — just unverifiable in advance.
Alicante CSIdiomas	Runs the only staffed extranjería advice desk at any Spanish university — and publishes nothing about work rights.	INSTRUCTIVE See below.

THE ALICANTE PARADOX

Alicante runs the **service** and makes no **claim**. Extremadura makes the **claim** and runs no **service**. Two readings are available and the evidence does not choose between them: either CSIdiomas knows its students land on Route 2 and therefore has nothing positive to say, or it is simply careful — a desk that handles real files does not publish generalisations, while IELE's copy is recruitment marketing.

Either way, this is worth using: consultasextranjeria@csidiomas.ua.es handles exactly this question week in, week out. They are not your university, but they are the best-informed people in Spain you can email for free.

NOBODY HAS PUBLICISED THE INSTRUCTION

Fourteen months after Instrucción SEM 3/2025 was issued — an instruction whose stated purpose is to help universities internationalise by bringing their language courses into Route 1 — **not one Spanish university mentions it anywhere**. The one centre publishing consequences consistent with it (IELE) does so without citing it. You will have to raise it yourself.

The four emails

Everything unresolved in this document can be settled for €0 by sending these. Send them before you pay any deposit.

THE TRICK

Do not ask "can I work?" — every centre answers that with marketing. Ask "what did your previous students' TIEs say?" A question about the historical record is much harder to answer evasively than a question about the future.

- 1 **To IELE Cáceres — the one that decides your plan**
To **seciele@unex.es**, cc **diriele@unex.es**. This version works because they have already published the claim — you are asking them to stand behind their own words.

Asunto: Consulta previa a la matrícula — artículo de concesión de la autorización de estancia

Estimados señores:

En sus preguntas frecuentes indican que el visado "entitles the holder to obtain a TIE and to work up to 30 hours per week during the period of study", y su folleto del Intensive Spanish Program añade que el permiso puede prorrogarse desde España y transformarse en un permiso de trabajo.

*Entiendo que ello implica que la autorización se concede como **estudios superiores del art. 52.1.a)** del RD 1155/2024 (Instrucción Primera de las Instrucciones SEM 3/2025) y no como estudios idiomáticos del art. 52.1.e).2º. ¿Me lo pueden confirmar?*

¿Podrían indicarme qué han hecho constar las TIE de sus alumnos de ediciones anteriores, y si efectivamente han podido trabajar 30 horas semanales sin autorización adicional?

*Asimismo, ¿el curso conduce a un **título expedido por la Universidad** (título propio aprobado por el Consejo Social conforme al art. 37 del RD 822/2021) o únicamente a un certificado de asistencia o aprovechamiento?*

Muchas gracias por su ayuda.

Aziz Dardouri — Tunecino — Pasaporte nº [...]

Confirms the article, asks for the historical TIE record, and settles the *título* vs *certificado* question from Chapter 3 — all in one message.

SEND THIS FIRST. IT DECIDES EVERYTHING.

To any other centre you are considering

The generic version, for centres that have published nothing. Send to the language centre and cc the international office.

Estimados señores:

Antes de formalizar la matrícula en el [nombre del curso], necesito confirmar un punto sobre extranjería.

*¿Bajo qué apartado del artículo 52.1 del Reglamento aprobado por el Real Decreto 1155/2024 se han venido concediendo las autorizaciones de estancia a sus alumnos de este curso: como **estudios superiores** del art. 52.1.a) —conforme a la Instrucción Primera de las Instrucciones SEM 3/2025, de 20 de junio, que califica como estudios superiores los estudios idiomáticos presenciales impartidos por centros de educación superior reconocidos— o como **estudios idiomáticos** del art. 52.1.e).2º?*

Según su experiencia con alumnos de ediciones anteriores: (1) ¿qué constaba en sus TIE en el apartado de tipo de autorización u observaciones?, y (2) ¿pudieron trabajar hasta 30 horas semanales sin solicitar una autorización de trabajo adicional?

Muchas gracias.

Aziz Dardouri — Tunecino — Pasaporte nº [...]

Cites the instruction by name, which no university has publicised. Expect some confusion — that is itself informative.
REUSABLE FOR ZARAGOZA, MÁLAGA, GRANADA, CÓRDOBA, VALLADOLID, VALENCIA...

To a Group C centre — the *convenio* question

Only for centres run by a company or foundation (Salamanca, Alcalá, Alicante, Santiago). One paragraph:

*¿Existe un **convenio vigente de colaboración** con la Universidad para la impartición de este curso, y puede la Universidad expedir una certificación en la que conste que los estudios están conveniados en el curso académico correspondiente, junto con un resumen del plan de estudios? Lo necesito para el expediente de visado, conforme al §9 de los Criterios de Gestión de 23 de junio de 2025.*

"Is there a collaboration agreement in force with the University for delivering this course, and can the University issue a certification stating that the studies are covered by an agreement for the relevant academic year, together with a summary of the study plan? I need it for the visa file, per §9 of the Management Criteria of 23 June 2025."

IF THEY CANNOT PRODUCE THE *CONVENIO*, WALK AWAY.

To the Oficina de Extranjería itself

Once you have the university's written answer, put it to the office that will actually decide your file.

CHANNEL `sede.administracionespublicas.gob.es/ayuda/consulta/ExtranjeriaCG`

OFFICES The dropdown includes Cáceres and Zaragoza. Free text, reply by email, trackable by incident number.

SAY Attach the university's answer, quote Instrucción SEM 3/2025 Primera.1, and ask under which subsection of art. 52.1 the authorisation would be granted.

DO NOT USE THE WRONG URL

The same address **without CG on the end** is IT support only — website faults, appointment-app errors. It is run by a different ministry and will not answer a legal question.

Who to ask, and what it costs

Free channels first. Spend money only if the free ones fail — and then only with the Chapter 3 text in hand.

Free — and staffed by actual lawyers

BODY	CONTACT	NOTES
SAOJI Zaragoza BEST FREE OPTION	inmigracion@aragon.es +34 976 71 46 67 Mon–Fri 09:00–12:00 C/ Prudencio 11, 50071 Zaragoza citaprevia.aragon.es/provincias	Immigration-specific service run jointly by the Gobierno de Aragón and the Aragonese bars — you get a real <i>colegiado</i> , not a caseworker. First consultation free to everyone . Case-handling is means-tested at 2× IPREM (~€15,360/yr), but you only need the consultation.
CSIdiomas Alicante extranjería desk	consultasextranjeria@csidiomas.ua.es +34 96 590 3933 Mon–Fri 09:00–14:00 Thu also 16:00–18:00	The only staffed visa/extranjería desk at any Spanish university. Not your institution — but they handle this exact question for their own language centre every week.
ICA Cáceres — SOJ	927 245 184 · Mon–Fri 09:00–14:00 sojgeneral@icacaceres.es Palacio de Justicia, Avda. Hispanidad, 3ª pl. walk-in Mon–Fri 09:00–11:00	Cáceres bar association's free legal orientation service. Covers <i>protección internacional y extranjería</i> . Your local option once you are in Cáceres.
ICA Badajoz — SOJ	924 59 03 75 icaba.es/ciudadanos/solicitud-citaprevia-s-o-j Mon/Wed/Thu 10:00–14:00, 17:00–20:00	Also serves Mérida and Villanueva de la Serena.
Accem Extremadura	927 209 079 · extremadura@accem.es C/ Argentina 3, Entreplanta B, 10001 Cáceres	NGO. Practical help with paperwork rather than legal opinions.

Paid — two verified firms

FIRM	CONTACT	WHY THIS ONE
Ciriano & Moreno Zaragoza César David Ciriano Vela	976 249 518 cciriano@reicaz.com Paseo Independencia 24–26, planta 7, of. 10 50004 Zaragoza	Free initial consultation. Works in English, French and German. Has a dedicated <i>visado de estudiante</i> service page. The @reicaz.com address independently confirms bar membership.
Katibi Abogados Cáceres / Badajoz / Madrid	+34 634 71 71 39 administracion@katibiabogados.com Avda. Virgen de la Montaña 3, 1ªA, Cáceres Mon–Fri 10:00–14:00 / 16:30–20:30	Works in Arabic and French . Their Cáceres office is on the same street as IELE. No published student-visa work, and consultation price not published.

Key contacts at the four main centres

CENTRE	PEOPLE AND ADDRESSES
IELE Cáceres	Dr. Francisco Jiménez Calderón – Director – diriele@unex.es Dr. David Carmona Centeno – Secretario Académico – seciele@unex.es Teresa Durán Calvo – administración/facturación – contafuex@unex.es Avda. Virgen de la Montaña 14, 10002 Cáceres · +34 682 38 66 98 Mon–Fri 09:00–14:00 · staff speak English, Portuguese, Italian, Dutch
CELE Zaragoza	ele@unizar.es · eleintensivo@unizar.es · 976 761 047 Interfacultades, 3ª planta, C/ Pedro Cerbuna 12, 50009 Zaragoza Mon–Fri 09:00–14:00 · service in ES / EN / FR
CIE Málaga	cie@uma.es · +34 951 952 738 Avda. de la Estación de El Palo 4, 29017 Málaga UMA International Hub: internationalhub@uma.es · +34 951 953 126
CLM Granada	info@clm.ugr.es · (+34) 958 215 660 Placeta del Hospicio Viejo s/n, 18009 Granada UGR international: intlinfo@ugr.es · +34 958 249 030

BEFORE YOU PAY ANY LAWYER

No practitioner in Spain has written about the Chapter 3 question. A general extranjería lawyer will most likely read the two articles back to you at €80–150 an hour. **Put the Criterios §9 passage and the Instrucción Primera in front of them at instruction** and ask them to address that specific test — otherwise you are paying someone to rediscover what is already in this document.

The complete directory

Every Spanish university language centre found, with the price, the calendar and the paperwork. Sorted by how well it fits a January 2027 start.

HOW TO READ THE COLUMNS

Days is the course length from the January start. **+45** adds the month before and fortnight after that Art. 55.2 allows — if that total passes **181 days**, the authorisation exceeds six months and you get a TIE and a real residence. Below it, a stamp and a flight home.

Run by matters only for Group C centres: a separate company or foundation needs the *convenio* question from Chapter 5.

Cerv. is Instituto Cervantes accreditation — it is the gate to Route 2 and irrelevant to Route 1, listed only for completeness.

Every price was read off the centre's own page. **Where a page carried a stale academic year, it is flagged.** "not publ." means the figure genuinely is not published — that is a finding, not a gap.

GROUP 1 January 2027 start, clears six months

These give you a TIE, real residence, and enough runway to apply for a master's from inside Spain.

CENTRE	CITY	PRICE	STARTS	ENDS	DAYS	+45	H/WK	CERV.
IELE — Extremadura	Cáceres	2.500	18 Jan	18 Dec 2027	335	380	20	✓
CSIdiomas — Alicante	Alicante	6.200	7 Jan	~Nov 2027 (44 wks)	308	353	15	—
Centro de Idiomas — León	León	3.600	7 Jan	17 Dec 2027 (3 trim.)	344	389	20	—
CSIdiomas — Alicante	Alicante	4.500	7 Jan	32 wks	224	269	15	—
CCEE — Complutense	Madrid	5.550	8 Jan	28 Jul 2027	202	247	25	—
Univ. de La Rioja	Logroño	2.725	11 Jan	16 Jun 2027	157	202	20	—
Univ. de León (2 trim.)	León	2.600	7 Jan	4 Jun 2027	149	194	20	—
Cursos Intl. USC	Santiago	2.691	7 Jan	~early Jun (21 wks)	147	192	20	—
CIE — Málaga (stacked)	Málaga	ca. 8.800	8 Jan	20 Dec 2027	346	391	20	✓

THE +45 IS NOT AUTOMATIC

Instrucción TERCERA.1 says the extra month and fortnight are **optional and waivable in writing**. Cáceres, Alicante, León's three-trimester block and Complutense clear six months on course length alone. La Rioja, Santiago and León's two-trimester block clear it **only if the padding is granted**. Do not build on the padding.

GROUP 2 January start, but under six months

Legal — all clear the 91-day minimum — but they end in spring and send you home. Useful only if you plan a second application.

CENTRE	CITY	PRICE	STARTS	ENDS	DAYS	H/WK
Centro de Estudios Hispánicos — Nebrija	Madrid	4.510	8 Jan	20 May 2027	133	15
CELE — Zaragoza	Zaragoza	1.360	11 Jan	19 May 2027	129	20
Casa de las Lenguas — Oviedo	Oviedo	1.625	11 Jan	14 May 2027	124	n/p
Estudios Hispánicos — UB	Barcelona	1.714	18 Jan	22 Apr 2027	94	8
CLM — Granada (CILE modules)	Granada	3.262 / 280h	8 Jan	modular	—	20
Idiomes UAB	Barcelona	236 / week	monthly	rolling	—	20
CUI — Pablo de Olavide	Sevilla	2.655 / sem	25 Jan	semester	~131	n/p
Idiomes UPF 640H COURSE CLOSED	Barcelona	270 / 30h	25 Jan	16 Mar 2027	51	4

GROUP 3 Real programmes with no January entry

CENTRE	CITY	FULL YEAR	NEXT START	H/WK	RUN BY
Univ. de Almería COAST	Almería	2.700 / 600h VERIFY	1 Oct 2026; Feb intake exists, 2027 unpublished	20	Fundación UAL
Univ. de Burgos	Burgos	3.000 / 620h	19 Aug 2026	n/p	UBU's own
Servicio de Idiomas — Murcia COAST	Murcia	1.575 / 300h	Feb–May 2027	~18	UM's own
Centro de Idiomas UVa 2025-26 PRICE	Valladolid	3.570 / 425h	"Jan–mid-May"	15–16	Fundación UVa
Centro de Idiomas UC3M	Madrid	4.000 / 600h	7 Oct 2026 — window closed	20	Fundación UC3M
Alcalingua	Alcalá	5.310 / 600h	1 Oct 2026	16–17	S.R.L. B82335902
UCOIdiomas	Córdoba	5.088 / 600h	14 Sep 2026 / 15 Feb	n/p	S.L. B14534739
ILCE — Navarra	Pamplona	7.080 (60 ECTS)	"Enero–Mayo", no date	~20	UNAV institute
ESTO — UCLM 2023-24 PRICE	Toledo	5.845 → 7.355 total / 900h	11 Sep – 31 Jul (pattern only)	20	Fundación UCLM
CEH — URV	Tarragona	not published / 600h+120h	Oct–Jun, no dates	4	URV + Fundació URV
Estudios Hispánicos — UB (visa programme)	Barcelona	6.444 / 580h	9 Sep 2026	20	UB's own unit
Centre d'Idiomes UV COAST	Valencia	408 / 60h	winter sem. ends 25 Jan	4	FGUV
Institut de Llengües — UdL	Lleida	208–292 / 50–70h	5 Oct 2026	4–6	UdL's own
Centro de Lenguas UPV 2025-26 PRICE	Valencia	450 / 48h	10 Feb	4	UPV's own

FOUR PRICES THAT ARE NOT PUBLISHED — AND WHY

URV Tarragona confirms the annual course exists ("*duración anual, de octubre a junio, con 600 horas lectivas y 120 horas de talleres*") and gives no fee anywhere, including in its own 42-page brochure. Only by writing to ceh@urv.cat.

Idiomes UPF's 640-hour, eight-month immersion course has no public price **by design**: enrolment is routed to an agency in China — "*contactar directament amb la nostra col·laboradora a la Xina, Hangzhou Cervantes Education Technology.*" Effectively closed to an individual applicant from Tunisia.

Universidad de Sevilla's Centro Internacional lists three products under a heading "FECHAS Y PRECIOS" that is **empty in the page source**. It still carries a footnote about academic year **17/18**.

Universidad de Almería shows no euro figures on any published course page — the €2,700 and €1,500 above come from the enrolment widget's own data feed, which is what the booking form displays. Confirm before relying on it. Their site says "*Preparando oferta de cursos para el 26/27... En breve publicaremos el catálogo definitivo.*"

GROUP 4 Too short or too thin to support a visa

Fewer than 91 days, or so few weekly hours that no full-time claim survives contact with an officer.

CENTRE	CITY	WHAT THEY ACTUALLY OFFER	H/WK
Centro Intl. de Estudios de Español — UIB	Palma	60h max; longest block 75 days	7.5
Instituto de Lenguas — UCV	Valencia	75h cuatrimestral, 525 € (91 days exactly)	4
CSLM — Cádiz	Cádiz	Longest 72 days; 3-week Jan intensive 267 €	~18
CIUC — Cantabria	Santander	60h quadrimester; Jan intensive 40h, 221 €	5
CIDE — Deusto 25/26 PRICE	Bilbao	Semester 650 € (99 days)	4
Servicio de Idiomas — UPCT	Cartagena	2nd sem 18 Feb–29 May (101 d), 125 €	2.5
Instituto de Idiomas — Sevilla	Sevilla	45h 212 € / 90h 425 €	3
ILM — Univ. San Jorge	Zaragoza	Free , 75h per semester	3.3
SLT — Jaume I	Castellón	Nothing reaches 91 days ; 70h maximum	10.5
Centro Superior de Idiomas — UPNA	Pamplona	Flexible semester 599 €	1.5–2
Servicio de Idiomas — ULL	Tenerife	50h quadrimester, 250 €	3
Centro de Lenguas — UDC	A Coruña	30h courses, 78 days	3
Centro de Linguas — Vigo	Vigo	60h 285 € / 120h 570 €	4
CEALM — Jaén PAGES STALE	Jaén	60h, 300 €	4
SLM — Huelva 2024 FEES	Huelva	45h, 190 €	~3
Servicio de Idiomas — UAM	Madrid	150h/year, only 70 contact hours	3
Centro de Lenguas — UPM	Madrid	60h per semester	4
Dpto. de Español — UNEATLÁNTICO 2025 DATES	Santander	Extensiva 588 €	4
Centro de Idiomas — UMH	Elche	A2 semi-online only; price page blank	n/p

GROUP 4B Private universities and university-affiliated centres

Eighteen private universities and four university-affiliated centres, checked separately. Only a handful sell a course you could actually buy.

INSTITUTION	CITY	PRICE	CALENDAR	VERDICT
UCAM — Fundación Univ. San Antonio	Murcia / Madrid	5.290 / 730h	"Comienzo Octubre "	Real programme, no January cohort
UPSA — Observatorio de la Lengua Española	Salamanca	not published	Any Monday ; beginners 1st Monday of the month, except January	Only truly flexible centre in Spain — but no price and no 2026-27 calendar
FUNCARELE (UPCT is a <i>patrono</i>)	Cartagena	159 / week + 50	No 2027 dates published	Explicitly visa-built; ~7.632 €/yr; best refund clause anywhere
ELE USAL Bilbao FRANCHISE	Bilbao	7.500 / year	Every Monday	Not USAL — a separate S.L. (B95963534). Route 2 only
ELE USAL Mallorca FRANCHISE	Palma	4.150 / 24 wks 2022	Every Monday	Operating company not named in any document
IUNIT ADSCRITO URJC · RUCT 28054816	Madrid	not published	none published	Strong on paper; no price, no dates, no visa page
Univ. Católica de Ávila — AULCE	Ávila	790 / 60h	June–July only	Nothing near 91 days
Alfonso X el Sabio	Madrid	2.400	—	Buyable only with a degree place
UIC Barcelona	Barcelona	460 / 60h blended	undated	2.5 h/week on-site
Abat Oliba CEU	Barcelona	600 external	CATALOGUE 2021-22	2.5 h/week
IE University	Segovia / Madrid	—	—	Internal service for its own degree students
Loyola · Mondragón · Villanueva · UCJC	various	not published	—	Exchange students only, 26–40 hours
Cardenal Herrera CEU	Valencia	not published	not published	Teaches in person; publishes nothing

UVic-UCC	Vic	not published	PAGE DATED 2021	Abandoned page
UEMC Valladolid · Fernando Pessoa Canarias	—	—	—	ELE page removed / none exists
Univ. Europea (Valencia, Canarias, Madrid)	—	625 / 6 months	rolling	Online only — fails <i>presencial</i> , despite being sold as a <i>título propio</i>

TWO WARNINGS ON THE ELE USAL NETWORK

These schools trade on the Universidad de Salamanca name. They are **franchises** — the network's own site calls it "*el sistema de franquicias*" and lists "*Master Franquicia China*" and "*Master Franquicia Brasil*" as members. USAL licenses the brand and the teaching manuals; it issues no diploma and owns none of the schools.

The brand owner's website, eleusal.com, is **currently compromised** — the homepage carries injected online-casino link spam in four languages. And ELE USAL Mallorca's legal notice was published with the placeholder unfilled: "*es titularidad de RAZÓN SOCIAL DE LA ESCUELA*". No published document names the company that runs that school.

GROUP 5 Ruled out, and why

INSTITUTION	REASON
Cursos Internacionales de Salamanca S.A.U.	No course reaches 91 days — the longest is 68. The year-long <i>Diploma de Estudios Hispánicos</i> returns "Invalid course id" and is absent from the sitemap. Not accredited, and legally a company (A37208105).
UIMP Santander	Summer only, maximum four weeks. Nothing approaches 91 days, despite advertising itself as a year-round Spanish centre.
UPV/EHU (Basque Country)	" <i>Estos cursos no están abiertos a estudiantado ajeno a la EHU.</i> " Closed to outsiders.
ULPGC Las Palmas	Spanish is offered online only , asynchronous, zero contact hours — fails the <i>presencial</i> requirement outright.
Universitat de Girona	Teaches no Spanish. The Servei de Llengües Modernes catalogue covers German, English, French and Catalan only.
Universitat Ramon Llull	No Spanish-for-foreigners programme. Its Serveis Lingüístics exist for Catalan.
Universidad Europea de Madrid	No language centre exists. The only "Spanish Courses" page is generic online marketing.
UNIA	No language centre. Postgraduate and summer courses only.
Comillas · CEU San Pablo · URJC · Francisco de Vitoria · Centro Internacional de Sevilla	Nothing published — no prices, no calendars. URJC's "Español Intensivo" page renders empty; UFV still advertises August 2017; Sevilla's page carries a footnote about academic year 17/18.

ONE PUBLISHED CLAIM THAT IS FALSE

The **Centro Universitario Internacional de la Universidad Pablo de Olavide** states on its own site: *"El Centro Universitario Internacional es desde el 1 de Marzo de 2008 Centro Acreditado del Instituto Cervantes."* It **does not appear in the register**. The Seville list was checked in full — thirteen accredited centres, UPO among none of them. Treat the claim as lapsed, and treat anything else on that page with corresponding care.

Where this lands

The recommendation, the order of operations, and an honest list of what is still not verified.

Making the stay longer — the lever most applicants miss

The length of your authorisation is set by the length of what you enrol in. Three provisions make that worth exploiting.

Art. 55.1 — la autorización se concede por la duración oficial de los estudios en el supuesto del art. 52.1.a); en los demás supuestos, por un máximo de un año.

Under Route 1 the authorisation runs for the **full official duration of the studies** — no one-year cap. The one-year cap applies to the other categories, Route 2 among them.

ANOTHER REASON ROUTE 1 MATTERS

- **Criterios §4** — semester and quarterly enrolments are admissible, so a long period can be assembled from parts.
- **Criterios §6** — for a multi-year course, financial means need only be proved **for the first year**. A longer course does not mean a bigger frozen account.
- **Criterios §3** — insurance must cover the whole period **plus the 45 days**. An eleven-month course needs about twelve and a half months of cover. Budget for it.

THE PRACTICAL INSTRUCTION

Ask the centre for **one enrolment certificate covering the whole block** — start date, end date, total hours, weekly hours, on a single document. Not three receipts for three trimesters. The consulate reads one *certificado de matrícula* and grants the period it states.

A summer holiday **inside** that period is normal and does not shorten it. IELE's own year proves the point: 18 January to 18 December 2027, with a stated break from 30 June to 9 September, is still one eleven-month enrolment.

Add this line to the emails in Chapter 5. It may be the most valuable question in them:

*¿Es posible formalizar una **única matrícula** que cubra desde enero hasta diciembre de 2027, y que el certificado de matrícula indique el periodo completo, las horas totales y las horas semanales? Lo necesito así para la solicitud del visado.*

"Is it possible to make a single enrolment covering January to December 2027, with the enrolment certificate stating the full period, total hours and weekly hours? I need it in that form for the visa application."

ONE SENTENCE. IT CAN DOUBLE THE LENGTH OF YOUR PERMIT.

TWO LIMITS, SO YOU PLAN HONESTLY

The course must stay **genuinely full-time**. Criterios §15 carries an abuse-of-right doctrine, and Art. 200.2.c) makes it an **extinction** ground where the stay is used for other ends — *"especialmente si ha estado desempeñando una actividad laboral."* Twenty hours of real classes plus thirty hours of work is lawful and normal. Enrolling in a thin course to buy a long permit is not, and it is the kind of thing an officer notices at renewal.

Who will actually sell you eleven months in one enrolment

Three centres will, and the difference between them is money. These figures come from the centres' own booking engines, not their brochures.

CENTRE	ONE ENROLMENT	PRICE	HOW IT BOOKS
IELE Cáceres	18 Jan → 18 Dec 2027	2.500	Single checkout ticket, or 2 × 1.250 €
Univ. de León	7 Jan → 21 Dec 2027	3.600	Three trimester checkboxes on one form , 720h / 60 ECTS
CSIdiomas Alicante	7 Jan → 17 Dec 2027	6.665	One start-date + one end-date field; 8.820 € at 4h/day

LEÓN'S FOUR-MONTH HOLE

León's three trimesters leave a gap from **5 June to 5 October 2027** with no classes inside your enrolment. Cáceres has a break too, but it is ten weeks, not four months. A consulate may treat those differently.

Cannot be extended: La Rioja's enrolment form is single-select and lists only 2026-27 courses. Complutense's immersion block is fixed and needs a second *matrícula* to continue. Santiago caps at 21 weeks and publishes no end date. Nebrija sells January, spring, June and July as four separate products with no combined price.

Granada hides a longer ladder: its public table stops at 280 hours, but the enrolment form carries rates to 920 hours at **€11.65 per hour** above 280 — 520 hours, 8 January to 29 July 2027, €6,058 — conditional on "*que se haga la matrícula por el total de cursos de una sola vez.*"

Read the refund clause before you pay anyone

CENTRE	IF THE VISA IS REFUSED
IELE Cáceres	Refund minus €150 ; claim within 7 days, paid within 60. And a delayed visa lets you postpone to a later intake free: " <i>you may postpone the start of your course to a later edition without any inconvenience.</i> "
La Rioja	Refund minus €150
Alicante	Refund minus €150 — but 100% of the fee must be paid to obtain the registration certificate, and you must cancel 72 hours before the start
FUNCARELE Cartagena	" <i>te devolvemos todo el importe menos los gastos de gestión</i> " — the most generous clause found
León	Refund minus €500 once the invitation letter has been issued
Granada	No refund at all. " <i>La denegación de visado no se considera causa justificada para la devolución del importe abonado.</i> "

THIS ALONE RULES GRANADA OUT

Granada would take €6,058 up front and return nothing if Tunis refuses. No other centre in Spain has that clause.

Your whole plan, priced

IELE's pathway pages block most fetchers; they were retrieved for this guide. The **Master's Pathway** is exactly the route you are planning:

STAGE	COST
Year 1 — Spanish, A1 to B2, 20 h/week	2.500 €
Year 2 — the master's itself	860 – 5.000 €
Bachelor's Pathway (alternative)	4.500 €
Vocational Pathway — Year 1	2.500 € (FP years 0–400 €/yr)
One-Month Course	500 €

Language year plus master's at Extremadura: **€3,360 at the low end**. That sits inside your father's €8,000 with the frozen account, insurance, flights and living costs still to come — which is the only reason the whole plan works.

The recommendation

IELE, UNIVERSIDAD DE EXTREMADURA, CÁCERES – 11 JANUARY 2027 – €2,500

It is the only Spanish university language centre that publicly asserts the full Route 1 package. It is Cervantes-accredited **and** a university centre. It has a confirmed January intake. It costs half what Salamanca or Complutense cost. And Instrucción SEM 3/2025 covers it on the Ministry's own wording.

Your filter was never "which universities qualify" — nearly all of them do. Your filter is four things, and Cáceres is the only centre that clears all four:

- ☐ A **January 2027 intake** — most centres enrol in September and October only
- ☐ Around **€2,500**, not €5,000 — Salamanca, Complutense and Navarra are roughly double
- ☐ Long enough to clear the **91-day minimum** and the six-month TIE threshold comfortably
- ☐ A centre that will **put in writing** what article its students get

The fourth is the one that separates it. The others are not disqualified — they are silent, and silence costs you the ability to check before you pay.

Order of operations

NOW – COSTS €0

Send email 1 to IELE. Send email 2 to Zaragoza and any other centre you are weighing. Wait for written answers.

ON THEIR REPLY

If IELE confirms 52.1.a) and a university-issued *título* — proceed. If they answer "certificado de asistencia" only, put the same question to Zaragoza and Málaga before deciding.

SAME WEEK

Put the written answer to the Oficina de Extranjería via the ExtranjeriaCG buzón, and to SAOJI Zaragoza. Both free.

IN PARALLEL – DO NOT WAIT

Start the degree equivalence, apostille and sworn translation in Tunis. These take months and are needed for the master's, not the visa.

IN PARALLEL

Begin Spanish at Instituto Cervantes Túnez. Zero → A2 is three 60-hour modules at 590 TND each (~€524 total). Intensives at 15 h/week finish a module in four weeks.

BY 30 SEPTEMBER 2026

DELE registration closes for the 14 November sitting. SIELE has no deadline and returns results in ~3 weeks — use SIELE if you miss this.

OCT–NOV 2026

Enrol at the chosen centre. Buy the insurance. Fund the account. File the visa at the Spanish consulate in Tunis.

11 JANUARY 2027

Course starts.

WITHIN 30 DAYS OF ARRIVAL

Empadronamiento, then the TIE appointment. **Check what the card says.**

THE LINE TO LOOK FOR ON YOUR TIE

A card issued under the weaker article prints **"NO AUTORIZA A TRABAJAR"**. That single line tells you which route you actually got — regardless of what anyone promised beforehand. If it appears, Art. 54.1§2 lets you file for the stronger authorisation **from inside Spain**, without going home to Tunis.

What is still not verified

Stated plainly, because you should not build on any of it without checking:

OPEN ITEM	STATUS
Whether a centre that is both a university's own and Cervantes-accredited falls under Route 1 or Route 2	UNRESOLVED IN THE PUBLISHED TEXTS. No tie-breaker exists. Emails 1 and 4 are the only route to an answer.
Whether IELE's course leads to a <i>título</i> or only a <i>certificado</i>	Their site says <i>"un certificado oficial de la UEx"</i> . Email 1 settles it.
IELE's exact January 2027 dates	UNRESOLVED Three IELE sources give two answers. Programme page: <i>"B) 18 January to 18 December 2027"</i> . FAQ: <i>"11 January to 17 December"</i> . Brochure (May 2026): <i>"11 January 2027"</i> . Two to one for 11 January, but the programme page is the one carrying the price. Settle this in writing before filing anything.
Prices and intake dates at most centres in Chapter 2	Marked "ask" where I could not verify a current published figure. Several price pages carry stale academic years.
Whether the Tunis consulate applies any language requirement	The Casablanca consular checklist contains none . Schools claiming an A2 is required are selling courses, not quoting law.
Master's admission timing and the December–September gap	Covered in the separate Cáceres Route guide. Unchanged by this research.

ON THE ERRORS IN THE EARLIER DRAFTS

Three earlier versions of the test in Chapter 1 were wrong, and one of them eliminated roughly twenty universities that in fact qualify. The cause was misreading Criterios §9 — a section about **outsourcing** — as a universal gate on Route 1. It is not. Everything in this document has been rebuilt from the source PDFs rather than from that reading, and the two filters that never existed (a *título propio* requirement and a 20-hour week) are set out in Chapter 1 so that nobody can sell them back to you.